***Board 1***
South Deals
None Vul

♠ A 10 2
♥ A J 7
♦ J 8 6 2
♣ K 6 5

♠ 8 7 5 4 3
♥ Q 10 3
♦ A 4
♣ J 10 3

♠ J 6
♥ 9 8 5 2
♦ 9 7 5
♣ A Q 9 8

♠ K Q 9
♥ K 6 4
♦ K Q 10 3
♣ 7 4 2

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♦ |
| Pass | 2NT | Pass | 3NT |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by North
Lead: ♥9

The bidding has been as shown. The contract is 3NT

Lead the ♥9, the top of nothing.

Your ♣s are so good that all your instincts tell you to lead the ♣8, and perhaps set up 3 winners.

If you had one more small ♣s your instincts would be right, but with only a 4-card suit you should think a little longer. Three tricks won't set this contract, so you must depend on partner winning something. And if partner is going to win something perhaps he will lead a ♣ and you might make FOUR tricks in the suit.

So lead the ♥9. You lead a high card so partner won't be tempted to return the suit when he gets the lead. Note that although this lead finesses partner's ♥Q, it didn't do anything that declarer wouldn't have done on his own.

Declarer must play ♦s to get some winners, and when West takes the ♦A he will surely switch to the ♣J. Down goes declarer.

***Board 2***
North Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 5<br>♥ K Q 9 6 3<br>♦ K 6<br>♣ K Q 10 9 6 | |
| ♠ K 10 8<br>♥ 7<br>♦ A 7 5 3 2<br>♣ 8 5 3 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ Q J 9 7 6 2<br>♥ A 8 5 4<br>♦ 4<br>♣ 7 4 |
| | ♠ A 4 3<br>♥ J 10 2<br>♦ Q J 10 9 8<br>♣ A J | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♥ | 2♠ | 3♦ |
| 3♠ | 4♣ | Pass | 4♥ |
| Pass | Pass | 4♠ | Dbl |
| All Pass | | | |

4♠X by East
Lead: ♠A

The bidding has been as shown. The contract is 4♠ doubled

Lead the ♠A.

East's 2♠ bid is a Weak-jump Overcall, based on a 6-card ♠ suit and a weak hand.

Either the ♦Q or ♥J would normally be good leads.

But on this deal West/East have clearly sacrificed against your almost certain ♥ game. Since they don't have enough high-card strength to make this contract declarer is hoping to get some ruffs.

The way to cut down the number of ruffs he can make is to lead a trump at every opportunity.

So take the ♠A and then play another ♠. Declarer will still be able to ruff one ♥ in dummy, but will be left with two losing ♥s and will be down 2. Without the two trump plays he could have ruffed all three of his ♥ losers and actually made the conract.

***Board 3***
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 10 6 4
♥ 6 4 2
♦ K 9 4 2
♣ A K J

♠ K 8 7 3
♥ Q 10 7 3
♦ 7 5
♣ 6 3 2

♠ Q 9 2
♥ K 8 5
♦ A 8 6
♣ 10 9 7 5

♠ A J 5
♥ A J 9
♦ Q J 10 3
♣ Q 8 4

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1NT |
| Pass | 3NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by South
Lead: ♥3

The bidding has been as shown. The contract is 3NT

Lead the ♥3, fourth highest in an attacking suit.

Sometimes it comes down to just this kind of choice. Do you lead fourth down from ♠ K 8 7 3 or from ♥ Q 10 7 3.

The presence of the ♥10 bolsters the ♥ suit enough to give it the edge.

The suits could be arranged something like shown at left. With a ♠ lead the presence of the ♠10 in dummy allows declarer to make a second ♠ trick, which happens to be declarer's ninth trick.

But when you lead the ♥3 it does not promote a ♥ winner for declarer, and left to his own devices, he cannot establish the ♠ winner.

***Board 4***
East Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 6 3<br>♥ K 6 3<br>♦ A 7 4<br>♣ 10 9 8 7 4 | |
| ♠ K Q J 9 5 4<br>♥ A J 10<br>♦ 6<br>♣ A 5 2 | | ♠ A 10<br>♥ 9 4<br>♦ K Q J 9 8 3<br>♣ K Q J |
| | ♠ 8 7 2<br>♥ Q 8 7 5 2<br>♦ 10 5 2<br>♣ 6 3 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1♦ | Pass |
| 1♠ | Pass | 3♦ | Pass |
| 3♠ | Pass | 4♠ | Pass |
| 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♦[2] | Pass |
| 6♠ | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by West
Lead: ♥3

The bidding has been as shown. The contract is 6♠

Lead the ♥3.

The ♣10 would probably be a very safe lead. But you don't want "safe", you want "attack".

Dummy has advertised a long, strong ♦ suit which declarer will no doubt establish for discards.

It is important for your side to create a winner before your ♦A is forced out. The most likely looking winner is your ♥K. So lead the small ♥ and hope partner has the Queen.

***Board 5***
South Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 5 3
♥ K Q J
♦ Q J 10 9 7
♣ A 10 4

♠ K Q J 10 8
♥ 7 5 2
♦ A 5
♣ 9 6 3

♠ 4
♥ 10 9 8 4
♦ 8 6 3 2
♣ K 8 7 2

♠ A 9 7 6 2
♥ A 6 3
♦ K 4
♣ Q J 5

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♠ |
| Pass | 2NT | Pass | 3NT |
| Dbl | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by North
Lead: ♠4

The bidding has been as shown. The contract is 3NT

Lead the ♠4.

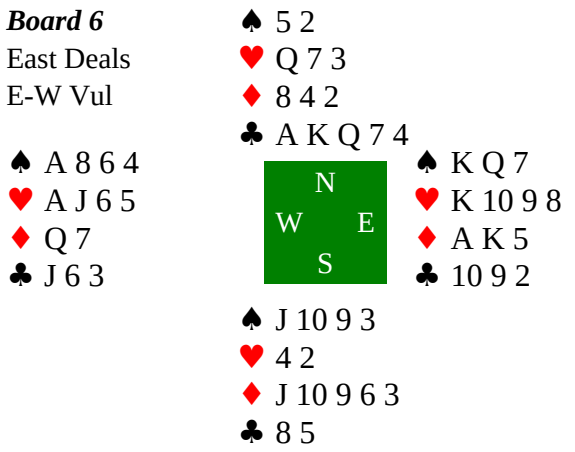
If partner had not doubled the contract you would probably have started with the ♥10, or possibly the ♣2.

But partner DID double, and most good players play that doubling 3NT is lead-directing as follows:If you have bid a suit, lead it. If doubler has bid a suit, lead it. If neither of you has bid, lead dummy's first bid suit.

So lead a ♠, certainly not a lead you would have made without the double. Partner immediately establishes 4 ♠ winners and he has the ♦A for an entry.

With any other lead declarer will make the contract.

***Board 6***
East Deals
E-W Vul




| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1NT | Pass |
| 2♣ | Dbl | 2♥ | Pass |
| 4♥ | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by East
Lead: ♣8

The bidding has been as shown. The contract is 4♥

Lead the ♣8.

If partner had not doubled West's Stayman 2♣ bid you would probably have started with one of your Jacks.

But partner **DID** double, and the double of a conventional bid clearly means that the doubler would like you to lead that suit.

So lead a ♣, and partner will take three ♣ tricks. With any other lead declarer would quickly discard a ♣ from dummy on a high ♦, easily making the contract.

Declarer may still make the contract if he guesses the ♥Q correctly, but maybe not.